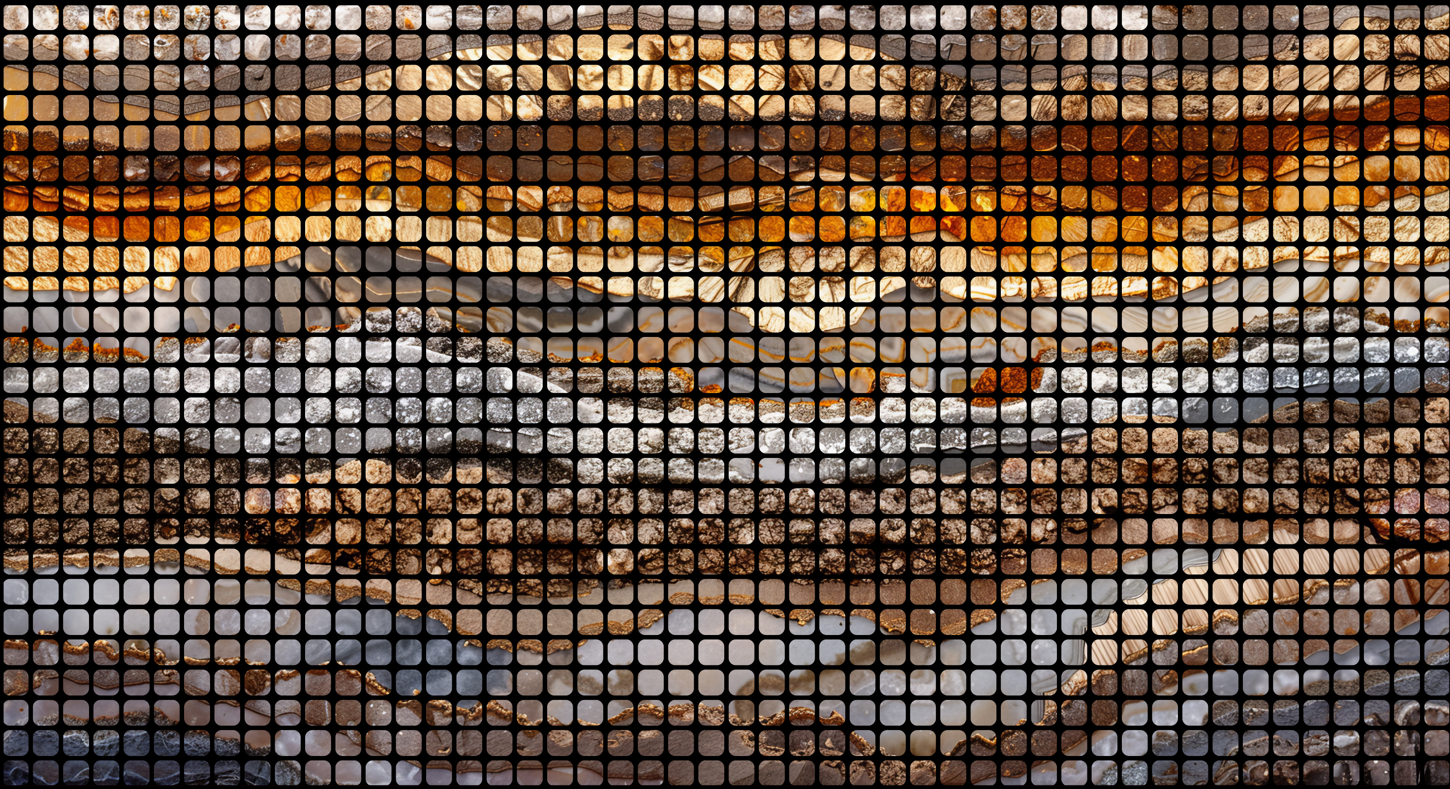

Digital Research Report

DeepSeek and the New Geopolitics of AI

China's ascent to research pre-eminence in AI

Daniel W. Hook

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1 Executive Summary

The topic of AI has become ubiquitous. We are already at the stage where it is almost impossible to escape from AI's effects on our lives. From the inevitable changes that will happen in the workplace as AI automates many jobs, to the fallout on how society functions in the light of a constant need for people to reskill or be left behind a rapidly changing work landscape. From extended lifespans through AI-managed health regimes to the immediate challenges of overpopulation. And, from facial recognition technology decreasing passport queues to the potential for police states to inhibit freedoms through surveillance tracking.

AI has the capacity to drive both profoundly positive and profoundly negative changes across global society. The difference between these positive outcomes and negative outcomes will not be binary with some good side and bad side, but rather in whether the ownership of the technology and the knowledge behind it is owned by the few or the many.

The development of AI-based technologies is going to be of critical importance over the next few years and hence having a deep understanding of the research landscape in which these technologies are being pioneered is key. This report selects some of the key geographies that are investing in AI research: China, the EU-27, the UK and the US, and seeks to understand the landscape from their perspective.

We find that:

1. AI has become a geopolitical lever, not just a research field.
2. The US continues to lead in AI-to-innovation translation via strong academia–industry links.
3. US influence in AI research is declining, with China now dominating. DeepSeek exemplifies China's technological independence.
4. The US remains a destination for researchers from around the world to do AI.
5. Both the US and UK see consistent talent flows toward China.
6. China is the top global AI collaborator, making it central to international research networks.
7. China's vast, young AI talent pool is driving sustained research expansion.
8. The UK remains small but globally impactful, consistently outperforming in attention-per-output across AI publications.
9. China has become the UK's primary AI collaborator, overtaking the US and EU.
10. The EU-27 benefits from strong internal AI collaboration across its research bloc.
11. Limited external engagement may hamper the EU-27's innovation dynamism in AI.
12. EU-27 underperforms in AI research visibility and translation to patents or business.